

A Fragmented Soviet Space Programme

If you look at the history of space programmes, and especially at the Space Race, a pattern becomes apparent. In the late 1940s and throughout the 1950s, the Americans were fragmented into several different factions, each trying their own methods and approaches to the problems of space technology. The Soviets, on the other hand, were more or less unified under the guidance of Sergei Korolev, the chief designer.

In the 1960s, though, this turned around on its head very quickly. The formation of NASA provided the US space programmes with the unified leadership that it sorely missed in the early stage of the Space Race. And under James Webb, the programme flourished like never before.

The Soviets, on the other hand, went the opposite way. Korolev's initial successes still put him at the top of the chain, but the general public's interest in space meant that it became an internal political hotspot. Rival designers started biting at Korolev's heels and taking away important projects by aligning themselves with different political representatives. As the internal political scenario of the Communist Party started deteriorating, so did the ability of the Soviet Space Programme to work with unified guidance.

A prime example of this is that of Vladimir Chelomei. The Ukrainian rocket engineer enjoyed the patronage of Soviet Premier Nikita Khrushchev and was given the prestigious projects of a manned moon mission and a manned space station, at a time when Korolev was much further ahead in that field. Chelomei's area of expertise had always been developing rockets, not the understanding of space, and this meant that he started from scratch with a group of scientists isolated from the research of Korolev and his group.

Another problem with the scenario was that while the Kennedy had announced his intention of putting a man on the moon by the end of the decade, it wasn't something that terribly interested Korolev. Emotionally, he did have a desire to beat the Americans, but scientifically, he had much grander projects in mind. Specifically, Korolev had been working extensively on a project to send manned missions to Mars and Venus, thus asserting



Sergei Korolev, the chief scientist of the Soviet Space Programme